



A matter of time: Post the CWC final, Chelsea will have a gap of only five weeks before the new season of the Premier League starts on August 15. AFP

In the 46th minute, an on-field collision with PSG keeper Gianluigi Donnarumma resulted in Musiala suffering a fractured fibula. “I know there are many things in life much more important than this, but for these guys, it’s their life. Someone like Jamal lives for this. He just came back from a setback, and then it happens in the way it happens. You feel powerless,” said Bayern manager Vincent Kompany.

While it is expected that Musiala will take at least four to five months to recover from the injury, it is unlikely that the midfielder will return to his best next season.

While it is yet to be seen how the 2025–26 season pans out for the CWC participants, it is a known fact that delayed injuries will occur due to the added stress of the tournament. But it will remain a grey area because the true extent is difficult to quantify.

Let’s take PSG and Real Madrid as examples — the two teams playing one of the most high-profile clashes in the CWC, which the former won 4–1 to reach the final.

PSG has played 65 matches this season. In its squad, the top three

outfield players who have played the most minutes so far are Achraf Hakimi (4668), William Pacho (4545), and Vitinha (4521). They now have less than a month to get match-fit again for the UEFA Super Cup final against Tottenham Hotspur. The 2025–26 Ligue 1 season starts just three days later.

Real Madrid has played 68 matches this season. In its squad, the top three outfield players with the most minutes are Federico Valverde (5556), Aurelien Tchouameni (4866), and Jude Bellingham (4794). Los Blancos finished their 2024–25 season on July 9 and will have 42 days (12 days more than PSG) before their regular La Liga 2025–26 season begins on August 20.

A potential deterrent

The CWC has also seen extreme weather conditions that have led to games being suspended for prolonged periods. Be it extreme heat or thunderstorm alerts, the natural flow of matches has taken a hit multiple times.

And this wasn’t something that was suddenly sprung on the

Statfile



No of matches played by PSG and Chelsea in 2024-25

PSG: 65; Chelsea: 64

Most individual minutes in each team

PSG: Achraf Hak'm' — 4668 m'ns;
Chelsea: Marc Cucurella — 4346 m'ns

organisers, because pre-tournament forecasts had already predicted such conditions.

The first match disrupted due to extreme weather was the Ulsan HD vs Mamelodi Sundowns clash on June 17 in Orlando, Florida, which was delayed for more than an hour due to the threat of lightning. On the same day, in Nashville, Tennessee, the Boca Juniors and Auckland City game saw a 50-minute pause due to FIFA’s lightning storm protocol being activated.

On June 18, the Pachuca vs Red Bull Salzburg match in Cincinnati, Ohio, suffered a one-hour and 37-minute delay due to heavy rainfall and lightning. The next day in East Rutherford, New Jersey, Palmeiras and Al Ahly’s match was suspended for 46 minutes due to lightning strikes, with a cooling break also needed midway through the first half as temperatures soared to 88°F (31.1°C).

On June 20, the longest delay of the tournament till then took place in Orlando, between Benfica and Auckland City, as play was suspended for two hours due to a lightning storm in the area. Benfica was the victim of another halt due to weather, with its clash against Chelsea taking four hours and 40 minutes to complete, following a one-hour and 53-minute delay just five minutes before full time.

While there have been numerous discussions on these climate-change-driven weather incidents, scorching temperatures have also been a major point of